

After Twenty Years

O. Henry · 1906

First published: New York Sunday World, 1906; The Four Million

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

Common Core edition (standards shown for this framework only)

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson 1: introduction (author, context, reception, overview)
4. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
5. Whole-book test and answer key
6. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Four_Million/After_Twenty_Years (revision 14234467), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 6–9 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 2 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does After Twenty Years suggest about loyalty and duty?
- What does After Twenty Years suggest about change over time?
- What does After Twenty Years suggest about friendship?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards: Common Core

RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4

Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org

Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five

Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	*Introduction: author, context and reception* After Twenty Years	2 × 90 min (180 min)	*loyalty and duty* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Introduction: author, context and reception • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Introduction to After Twenty Years

Author biography

O. Henry was the pen name of William Sydney Porter, born on 11 September 1862 in Greensboro, North Carolina. He trained as a pharmacist, moved to Texas, and worked as a draftsman, bank teller and humorous journalist. Convicted of embezzling from the Austin bank where he had worked (he maintained his innocence), he served about three years in the Ohio Penitentiary (1898–1901), where he began publishing stories as O. Henry. In New York he wrote a story a week for the New York World and produced hundreds of tales of ordinary city people, famous for their warmth, wordplay and twist endings. He died in New York on 5 June 1910.

Historical and cultural context

New York around 1900 had a new professional police force walking regular beats, and the West was still a place where young men went to make fortunes, honestly or not.

Publication and reception, then and now

First published in the New York Sunday World in 1906; collected in The Four Million (1906).

Then: Popular as one of O. Henry's neat "twist" stories.

Now: A standard middle-school text for foreshadowing, characterization and the surprise ending.

Overview (spoiler-free)

On a dark, rainy night a policeman walking his beat meets a man waiting in a doorway. The man explains he is keeping an appointment made twenty years ago with his best friend, Jimmy Wells.

Main themes

- loyalty and duty.
- change over time.
- friendship.

Why it matters

It raises a real ethical dilemma: what do we owe a friend who has done wrong?

Spoilers · teacher only

The policeman was Jimmy; recognizing the man as a wanted criminal, "Silky" Bob, he could not arrest his friend himself and sent a plainclothes officer with a note.

Lesson plan (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)

Before we open After Twenty Years: Would you turn in a friend who broke the law?
Prompt: Before we open After Twenty Years: Would you turn in a friend who broke the law?

8–18 min · Key terms · I do (10 min)

foreshadowing; twist ending; characterization; dilemma.

18–28 min · Mini-lecture: author, context, reception · I do (10 min)

About the author. O. Henry was the pen name of William Sydney Porter, born on 11 September 1862 in Greensboro, North Carolina. He trained as a pharmacist, moved to Texas, and worked as a draftsman, bank teller and humorous journalist. Convicted of embezzling from the Austin bank where he had worked (he maintained his innocence), he served about three years in the Ohio Penitentiary (1898–1901), where he began publishing stories as O. Henry. In New York he wrote a story a week for the New York World and produced hundreds of tales of ordinary city people, famous for their warmth, wordplay and twist endings. He died in New York on 5 June 1910. The world of the book. New York around 1900 had a new professional police force walking regular beats, and the West was still a place where young men went to make fortunes, honestly or not. Publication and reception. First published in the New York Sunday World in 1906; collected in The Four Million (1906). Then: Popular as one of O. Henry's neat "twist" stories. Now: A standard middle-school text for foreshadowing, characterization and the surprise ending.

28–40 min · I do: the book in one passage · I do (12 min)

"Twenty years is a long time, but not long enough to change a man's nose from a Roman to a pug" (After Twenty Years, paragraph 30). The plainclothes officer's giveaway.

> *Twenty years is a long time, but not long enough to change a man's nose from a Roman to a pug (After Twenty Years, paragraph 30)*

Think-aloud: "Twenty years is a long time, but not long enough to change a man's nose from a Roman to a pug" (After Twenty Years, paragraph 30). The plainclothes officer's giveaway.

40–55 min · We do: overview and themes · We do (15 min)

What the book is about (no spoilers): On a dark, rainy night a policeman walking his beat meets a man waiting in a doorway. The man explains he is keeping an appointment made twenty years ago with his best friend, Jimmy Wells. Themes to track: loyalty and duty.: change over time.: friendship.:

55–70 min · You do: reading journal · You do (15 min)

Set up a reading journal: one page per theme with a prediction and a question.
Task: Set up a reading journal for After Twenty Years: one page per theme, each with a prediction and a question.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)

Why does After Twenty Years still matter? It raises a real ethical dilemma: what do we owe a friend who has done wrong?
Anchor question: Why might After Twenty Years still be taught today?
Facilitation: It raises a real ethical dilemma: what do we owe a friend who has done wrong?

80–87 min · Exit ticket · You do (7 min)

Why didn't Jimmy arrest Bob himself? Answer: Out of loyalty and friendship; he did his duty but could not face doing it personally.
Exit ticket: Why didn't Jimmy arrest Bob himself?
Answer: Out of loyalty and friendship; he did his duty but could not face doing it personally.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)

Tomorrow we begin reading: After Twenty Years.

Teacher notes · sources: Britannica, "O. Henry" (https://www.britannica.com/biography/O-Henry); NCpedia, "Porter, William Sydney (O. Henry)" (https://www.ncpedia.org/biography/porter-william-sydney); O. Henry Museum (Austin) (https://www.austintexas.gov/department/o-henry-museum)

Lesson 2: After Twenty Years

Focus: friendship tested by duty

Content note (): No significant sensitive content flagged; preview as usual.
Student preview: Nothing in this story needs a special warning.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

A man waits in a New York doorway to meet his old friend Jimmy Wells, twenty years to the day after they parted. He tells a patrolling policeman about the plan. A man claiming to be Jimmy arrives, but he is a plainclothes officer who arrests the waiting man, 'Silky' Bob, wanted in Chicago. A note reveals that the patrolman was Jimmy, who recognized Bob as the wanted man and could not arrest him himself.

Background: Published in 1906 and collected in The Four Million, which names the ordinary New Yorkers O. Henry wrote about.

Significance: A compact surprise ending that rewards rereading for planted clues.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Would you turn in a friend who had done something seriously wrong? Why or why not? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to loyalty and duty because.... Content note before we start: Nothing in this story needs a special warning.
Prompt: Would you turn in a friend who had done something seriously wrong? Why or why not?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to loyalty and duty because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Jimmy keeps both the appointment and the law.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: submerged — sink below the surface; go under or as if under water; corresponded — exchanged letters; egotism — too much concern with oneself; unfolded — explained; revealed; vicinity — a surrounding or nearby region.
Words: submerged: sink below the surface; go under or as if under water · corresponded: exchanged letters · egotism: too much concern with oneself · unfolded: explained; revealed · vicinity: a surrounding or nearby region

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Published in 1906 and collected in The Four Million, which names the ordinary New Yorkers O. Henry wrote about. A compact surprise ending that rewards rereading for planted clues. Foreshadowing: The cop's careful questions and Bob's diamond scarfpin hint at the twist. Characterization: Bob is boastful and flashy; Jimmy is quiet and dutiful. Irony: Bob praises Jimmy as the most loyal friend in the world, and that loyalty to duty is what catches him. Watch for the appointment: loyalty that survives twenty years.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "Twenty years is a long time, but not long enough to change a man's nose from a Roman to a pug" (After Twenty Years, paragraph 30). The reveal. That is foreshadowing at work: The cop's careful questions and Bob's diamond scarfpin hint at the twist.

> *Twenty years is a long time, but not long enough to change a man's nose from a Roman to a pug (After Twenty Years, paragraph 30)*

Think-aloud: I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "Twenty years is a long time, but not long enough to change a man's nose from a Roman to a pug" (After Twenty Years, paragraph 30). The reveal. That is foreshadowing at work: The cop's careful questions and Bob's diamond scarfpin hint at the twist.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: The line warns that time "changes a good man into a bad one": Bob has changed, Jimmy has not. Ask: How does this line connect to loyalty and duty? Expected: Jimmy keeps both the appointment and the law. (The theme of change.)

> *It sometimes changes a good man into a bad one (After Twenty Years, paragraph 31)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: The line warns that time "changes a good man into a bad one": Bob has changed, Jimmy has not.
Ask: How does this line connect to loyalty and duty?
Expected answer: Jimmy keeps both the appointment and the law. (The theme of change.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)

Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).

Annotate the story for foreshadowing, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about friendship tested by duty? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how After Twenty Years develops the idea of friendship tested by duty. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and foreshadowing shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Jimmy proves his loyalty to both his friend and his duty. When the text says "Bob: I was at the appointed place on time" (After Twenty Years, paragraph 33), it shows this directly. His note says "I was at the appointed place on time," so he kept his promise, but he sent another officer because he was bound by duty and could not bear to arrest Bob himself.

Task: Annotate the story for foreshadowing, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about friendship tested by duty? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how After Twenty Years develops the idea of friendship tested by duty. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and foreshadowing shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)

Exemplar: Jimmy proves his loyalty to both his friend and his duty. When the text says "Bob: I was at the appointed place on time" (After Twenty Years, paragraph 33), it shows this directly. His note says "I was at the appointed place on time," so he kept his promise, but he sent another officer because he was bound by duty and could not bear to arrest Bob himself.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)

Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.

Anchor question: Would you turn in a friend who had done something seriously wrong? Why or why not? Ask: was Jimmy a good friend?

Anchor question: Would you turn in a friend who had done something seriously wrong? Why or why not?

Facilitation: Ask: was Jimmy a good friend?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)

Story quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).

Story quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about friendship tested by duty? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Jimmy proves his loyalty to both his friend and his duty. ("Bob: I was at the appointed place on time", After Twenty Years, paragraph 33). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about friendship tested by duty? Support it with one short quotation.

Answer: Model answer: Jimmy proves his loyalty to both his friend and his duty. ("Bob: I was at the appointed place on time", After Twenty Years, paragraph 33). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

> **87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)**
> Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
> *Today we saw how foreshadowing shapes friendship tested by duty. Key takeaway: Jimmy keeps both the appointment and the law.*

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Foreshadowing:** The cop's careful questions and Bob's diamond scarfpin hint at the twist.
- **Characterization:** Bob is boastful and flashy; Jimmy is quiet and dutiful.
- **Irony:** Bob praises Jimmy as the most loyal friend in the world, and that loyalty to duty is what catches him.

Themes and how they develop

- **loyalty and duty:** Jimmy keeps both the appointment and the law.

Symbols and motifs

- **the appointment:** loyalty that survives twenty years.

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- "Twenty years is a long time, but not long enough to change a man's nose from a Roman to a pug" (After Twenty Years, paragraph 30) The reveal.
- "It sometimes changes a good man into a bad one" (After Twenty Years, paragraph 31) The theme of change.
- "Bob: I was at the appointed place on time" (After Twenty Years, paragraph 33) Jimmy's note.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Jimmy proves his loyalty to both his friend and his duty.
Evidence: "Bob: I was at the appointed place on time" (After Twenty Years, paragraph 33)
Reasoning: His note says "I was at the appointed place on time," so he kept his promise, but he sent another officer because he was bound by duty and could not bear to arrest Bob himself.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
submerged (verb)	sink below the surface; go under or as if under water	*The other, submerged in his overcoat, listened with interest.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
corresponded (verb)	exchanged letters	*"Well, yes, for a time we corresponded," said the other.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

egotism (noun)	too much concern with oneself	*The man from the West, his egotism enlarged by success, was beginning to outline the history of his career.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
unfolded (verb)	explained; revealed	*The man from the West unfolded the little piece cf paper handed him.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
vicinity (noun)	a surrounding or nearby region	*The vicinity was one that kept early hours.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
dismally (adverb)	in a gloomy, depressing way	*The few foot passengers astir in that quarter hurried dismally and silently along with coat collars turned high and pocketed hands.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
doubtfully (adverb)	in an uncertain or unsure way	*"Is that you, Bob?" he asked, doubtfully.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
impressively (adverb)	in a way that commands notice or respect	*THE policeman on the beat moved up the avenue impressively.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. Would you turn in a friend who had done something seriously wrong? Why or why not?
2. Where does irony appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with loyalty and duty?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. How long ago did the two friends agree to meet? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Twenty years
2. Where is the waiting man from now? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: The West, Chicago
3. What clue shows the waiting man's wealth? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A diamond scarfpin and watch
4. Who was the patrolling policeman? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Jimmy Wells
5. Why did Jimmy send someone else to make the arrest? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: He could not bring himself to arrest his old friend
6. Retell the three most important events of "After Twenty Years" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A man waits in a New York doorway to meet his old friend

Jimmy Wells, twenty years to the day after they parted. He tells a patrolling policeman about the plan. A man claiming to be Jimmy arrives, but he is a plainclothes officer who arrests the waiting man, 'Silky' Bob, wanted in Chicago. A note reveals that the patrolman was Jimmy, who recognized Bob as the wanted man and could not arrest him…

7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in “After Twenty Years”? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does “After Twenty Years” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: “The other, submerged in his overcoat, listened with interest.” What does “submerged” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: submerged: sink below the surface; go under or as if under water.
10. Reread: ““Well, yes, for a time we corresponded,” said the other.” What does “corresponded” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: corresponded: exchanged letters.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does “After Twenty Years” suggest about friendship tested by duty? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A compact surprise ending that rewards rereading for planted clues.
2. Find one example of irony in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.6] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.
3. How does the foreshadowing in this story shape what we understand about friendship tested by duty? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: Look for hints, warnings or images that point to later events.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Jimmy proves his loyalty to both his friend and his duty. Useful evidence: “Twenty years is a long time, but not long enough to change a man’s nose from a Roman to a pug” (After Twenty Years, paragraph 30): The reveal. On foreshadowing: The cop's careful questions and Bob's diamond scarfpin hint at the twist. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. In the passage that begins “THE policeman on the beat moved up the avenue impressively.”, why might Henry have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “After Twenty Years”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: A man waits in a New York doorway to meet his old friend Jimmy Wells, twenty years to the day after they parted. He tells a patrolling policeman about the plan. A man claiming to be Jimmy arrives, but he is a plainclothes officer who arrests the waiting man, 'Silky' Bob, wanted in Chicago. A note…
6. As the opening story, what does “After Twenty Years” set up that the rest of After Twenty Years will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Jimmy proves his loyalty to both his friend and his duty. Useful evidence: “It sometimes changes a good man into a bad one” (After Twenty Years, paragraph 31):

The theme of change. Theme link: Jimmy keeps both the appointment and the law. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Jimmy proves his loyalty to both his friend and his duty. Useful evidence: “Bob: I was at the appointed place on time” (After Twenty Years, paragraph 33): Jimmy's note. On characterization: Bob is boastful and flashy; Jimmy is quiet and dutiful. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “Would you turn in a friend who had done something seriously wrong? Why or why not?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does characterization appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with loyalty and duty? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Jimmy proves his loyalty to both his friend and his duty. Useful evidence: “Twenty years is a long time, but not long enough to change a man’s nose from a Roman to a pug” (After Twenty Years, paragraph 30): The reveal. On characterization: Bob is boastful and flashy; Jimmy is quiet and dutiful. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Background: Published in 1906 and collected in The Four Million, which names the ordinary New Yorkers O. Henry wrote about. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Jimmy proves his loyalty to both his friend and his duty. Useful evidence: “It sometimes changes a good man into a bad one” (After Twenty Years, paragraph 31): The theme of change. Theme link: Jimmy keeps both the appointment and the law. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “A compact surprise ending that rewards rereading for planted clues.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Jimmy proves his loyalty to both his friend and his duty. Useful evidence: “Bob: I was at the appointed place on time” (After Twenty Years, paragraph 33): Jimmy's note. Theme link: Jimmy keeps both the appointment and the law. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Jimmy proves his loyalty to both his friend and his duty. Useful evidence: “Twenty years is a long time, but not long enough to change a man’s nose from a Roman

to a pug" (After Twenty Years, paragraph 30): The reveal. On characterization: Bob is boastful and flashy; Jimmy is quiet and dutiful. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

3. Rewrite one moment of "After Twenty Years" from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about friendship tested by duty? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.6] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Jimmy proves his loyalty to both his friend and his duty. Useful evidence: "It sometimes changes a good man into a bad one" (After Twenty Years, paragraph 31): The theme of change. Theme link: Jimmy keeps both the appointment and the law. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. Write three questions of your own about "After Twenty Years": one recall, one "why/how", and one "should/what if". Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Jimmy proves his loyalty to both his friend and his duty. Useful evidence: "Bob: I was at the appointed place on time" (After Twenty Years, paragraph 33): Jimmy's note. Theme link: Jimmy keeps both the appointment and the law. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Connect this story to change over time: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Henry need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Jimmy proves his loyalty to both his friend and his duty. Useful evidence: "Twenty years is a long time, but not long enough to change a man's nose from a Roman to a pug" (After Twenty Years, paragraph 30): The reveal. Theme link: Jimmy keeps both the appointment and the law. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Is the irony in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.6] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Jimmy proves his loyalty to both his friend and his duty. Useful evidence: "It sometimes changes a good man into a bad one" (After Twenty Years, paragraph 31): The theme of change. On irony: Bob praises Jimmy as the most loyal friend in the world, and that loyalty to duty is what catches him. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Compare how "After Twenty Years" treats friendship tested by duty with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does After Twenty Years see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Jimmy proves his loyalty to both his friend and his duty. Useful evidence: "Bob: I was at the appointed place on time" (After Twenty Years, paragraph 33): Jimmy's note. Theme link: Jimmy keeps both the appointment and the law. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. As the final story, does this ending resolve loyalty and duty? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Jimmy proves his loyalty to both his friend and his duty.

Useful evidence: “Twenty years is a long time, but not long enough to change a man’s nose from a Roman to a pug” (After Twenty Years, paragraph 30): The reveal. On foreshadowing: The cop's careful questions and Bob's diamond scarfpin hint at the twist. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about friendship tested by duty? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Jimmy proves his loyalty to both his friend and his duty. Useful evidence: “It sometimes changes a good man into a bad one” (After Twenty Years, paragraph 31): The theme of change. Theme link: Jimmy keeps both the appointment and the law. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. What question would you most like to ask O. Henry about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Jimmy proves his loyalty to both his friend and his duty. Useful evidence: “Bob: I was at the appointed place on time” (After Twenty Years, paragraph 33): Jimmy's note. Theme link: Jimmy keeps both the appointment and the law. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Irony:** look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Foreshadowing**: hints, warnings or images that point to later events
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them

Chapter quiz

1. How long ago did the two friends agree to meet?
   A. Ten years
   B. Twenty years
   C. Five years
   D. Fifty years
2. Where is the waiting man from now?
   A. The West, Chicago
   B. Boston
   C. London
   D. New Orleans
3. What clue shows the waiting man's wealth?
   A. A diamond scarfpin and watch
   B. A fur coat
   C. A new car

D. A bag of gold

4. Who was the patrolling policeman?
   A. Jimmy Wells
   B. Bob's brother
   C. A Chicago detective
   D. A stranger
5. Why did Jimmy send someone else to make the arrest?
   A. He could not bring himself to arrest his old friend
   B. He was off duty
   C. He was ordered to
   D. He was afraid
6. In the line “The other, submerged in his overcoat, listened with interest.”, what does “submerged” most nearly mean?
   A. exchanged letters
   B. explained; revealed
   C. too much concern with oneself
   D. sink below the surface; go under or as if under water
7. In the line ““Well, yes, for a time we corresponded,” said the other.”, what does “corresponded” most nearly mean?
   A. explained; revealed
   B. exchanged letters
   C. too much concern with oneself
   D. sink below the surface; go under or as if under water

Answer key: 1. B (Twenty years); 2. A (The West, Chicago); 3. A (A diamond scarfpin and watch); 4. A (Jimmy Wells); 5. A (He could not bring himself to arrest his old friend); 6. D (sink below the surface; go under or as if under water); 7. B (exchanged letters)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.6, W.7.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In “After Twenty Years,” how does Henry show friendship tested by duty? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the irony you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.6, W.9-10.1): In After Twenty Years, how does Henry develop the idea of friendship tested by duty? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the irony in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.6, W.9-10.1): Analyze how After Twenty Years develops the idea of friendship tested by duty. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual

evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and foreshadowing shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of After Twenty Years (where it begins, turns and ends) and its irony shape the reader's understanding of friendship tested by duty. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what After Twenty Years suggests about friendship tested by duty. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's irony and foreshadowing), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how O. Henry uses irony in After Twenty Years to complicate the reader's understanding of friendship tested by duty. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate After Twenty Years within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of friendship tested by duty responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read After Twenty Years alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of friendship tested by duty follows or bends those conventions, using the irony as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to After Twenty Years and its treatment of friendship tested by duty. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's irony and foreshadowing, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads After Twenty Years as evidence for a larger claim about friendship tested by duty in After Twenty Years. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads After Twenty Years as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of friendship tested by duty. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on After Twenty Years.

SAT-style questions

1. *The man from the West, his egotism enlarged by success, was beginning to outline the history of his career.*

As used in the text, what does the word "egotism" most nearly mean?

A. too much concern with oneself

B. in an uncertain or unsure way

C. in a gloomy, depressing way

D. in a way that commands notice or respect

2. *THE policeman on the beat moved up the avenue impressively. The impressiveness was habitual and not for show, for spectators were few. The time was barely 10 o'clock at night, but chilly gusts of wind with a taste of rain in them had well nigh depeopled the streets.*

Which choice best states a central concern of "After Twenty Years"?

A. Accepting one's place in nature's cycle

B. Friendship tested by duty

C. Hope created by an act of sacrifice

D. A girl's first encounter with death across the class line

SAT key: 1. A (too much concern with oneself); 2. B (Friendship tested by duty)

Whole-book test

After Twenty Years: whole-book test · 90 minutes

Part I: Multiple choice

1. How long ago did the two friends agree to meet?
   A. Ten years
   B. Twenty years
   C. Five years
   D. Fifty years
2. Where is the waiting man from now?
   A. The West, Chicago
   B. Boston
   C. London
   D. New Orleans
3. What clue shows the waiting man's wealth?
   A. A diamond scarfpin and watch
   B. A fur coat
   C. A new car
   D. A bag of gold
4. Who was the patrolling policeman?
   A. Jimmy Wells
   B. Bob's brother
   C. A Chicago detective
   D. A stranger
5. Why did Jimmy send someone else to make the arrest?
   A. He could not bring himself to arrest his old friend
   B. He was off duty
   C. He was ordered to
   D. He was afraid
6. In the line “The other, submerged in his overcoat, listened with interest.”, what does “submerged” most nearly mean?
   A. exchanged letters
   B. explained; revealed
   C. too much concern with oneself
   D. sink below the surface; go under or as if under water

7. In the line ““Well, yes, for a time we corresponded,” said the other.”, what does “corresponded” most nearly mean?
   A. explained; revealed
   B. exchanged letters
   C. too much concern with oneself
   D. sink below the surface; go under or as if under water
8. As used in the story (“The other, submerged in his overcoat, listened with interest.”), what does “submerged” mean?
   A. sink below the surface; go under or as if under water
   B. a surrounding or nearby region
   C. in a way that commands notice or respect
   D. explained; revealed
9. As used in the story (““Well, yes, for a time we corresponded,” said the other.”), what does “corresponded” mean?
   A. in a gloomy, depressing way
   B. exchanged letters
   C. sink below the surface; go under or as if under water
   D. a surrounding or nearby region
10. As used in the story (“The man from the West, his egotism enlarged by success, was beginning to outline the history of his career.”), what does “egotism” mean?
    A. in an uncertain or unsure way
    B. exchanged letters
    C. too much concern with oneself
    D. in a gloomy, depressing way
11. As used in the story (“The man from the West unfolded the little piece cf paper handed him.”), what does “unfolded” mean?
    A. in a way that commands notice or respect
    B. too much concern with oneself
    C. in an uncertain or unsure way
    D. explained; revealed
12. As used in the story (“The vicinity was one that kept early hours.”), what does “vicinity” mean?
    A. a surrounding or nearby region
    B. sink below the surface; go under or as if under water
    C. explained; revealed
    D. in a way that commands notice or respect

Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how loyalty and duty develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
2. Explain how change over time develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

3. Explain how friendship develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (loyalty and duty, change over time, friendship) and argue how the ending reframes it.

Answer key

Answer key: 1. B (Twenty years); 2. A (The West, Chicago); 3. A (A diamond scarfpin and watch); 4. A (Jimmy Wells); 5. A (He could not bring himself to arrest his old friend); 6. D (sink below the surface; go under or as if under water); 7. B (exchanged letters); 8. A (sink below the surface; go under or as if under water); 9. B (exchanged letters); 10. C (too much concern with oneself); 11. D (explained; revealed); 12. A (a surrounding or nearby region)

Essay assignments

Essay: Loyalty and duty

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what After Twenty Years teaches about loyalty and duty. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how O. Henry develops loyalty and duty in After Twenty Years. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how O. Henry develops loyalty and duty across After Twenty Years. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of After Twenty Years (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of loyalty and duty. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of loyalty and duty in After Twenty Years. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how O. Henry's choices in After Twenty Years (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of loyalty and duty, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places After Twenty Years's treatment of loyalty and duty in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on loyalty and duty in After Twenty Years that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on loyalty and duty in After Twenty Years. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about loyalty and duty in After Twenty Years, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on loyalty and duty in After Twenty Years, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Change over time

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what After Twenty Years teaches about change over time. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how O. Henry develops change over time in After Twenty Years. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how O. Henry develops change over time across After Twenty Years. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of After Twenty Years (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of change over time. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of change over time in After Twenty Years. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how O. Henry's choices in After Twenty Years (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of change over time, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places After Twenty Years's treatment of change over time in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on change over time in After Twenty Years that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on change over time in After Twenty Years. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about change over time in After Twenty Years, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on change over time in After Twenty Years, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Friendship

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what After Twenty Years teaches about friendship. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how O. Henry develops friendship in After Twenty Years. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how O. Henry develops friendship across After Twenty Years. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of After Twenty Years (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of friendship. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of friendship in After Twenty Years. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how O. Henry's choices in After Twenty Years (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of friendship, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places After Twenty Years's treatment of friendship in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on friendship in After Twenty Years that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on friendship in After Twenty Years. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about friendship in After Twenty Years, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on friendship in After Twenty Years, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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